

Champion migrator

The Arctic tern raises its chicks in the Arctic during the brief summer period. Then it flies 8,000 miles (13,000 km) to Antarctica to take advantage of the summer months there when plenty of food is available. This is the longest migration route of any bird. An Arctic tern can live for 30 years or more, so it may travel more than 500,000 miles (800,000 km) in its lifetime.

Arctic tern
(*Sterna paradisaea*)
Length: up to 14 in
(36 cm)

Beluga whale
(*Delphinapterus leucas*)
Length: up to 14 ft 9 in (4.5 m)

Sea canary

Beluga or white whales communicate with each other using a variety of songs, leading 19th-century sailors to know them as "sea canaries." They also make clicking noises that bounce off objects around them and help them find their way around.

In winter, beluga whales gather together in huge herds and migrate south.

Mountain hare
(*Lepus timidus*)
Body length: up to
1 ft 10 in (55 cm)
Tail: up to 2.5 in
(6.5 cm)



Changing color

The Mountain hare can change the color of its coat to match its surroundings. In the winter, its fur is white and gray. This makes it hard to see against the snow. In spring, when the snow melts, the hare sheds its white fur and grows a brown coat.

Common eider
(*Somateria mollissima*)
Length: up to 2 ft 4 in (71 cm)

Island nests

The common eider duck breeds among clumps of grass on small islands in the Arctic Ocean. These remote nesting sites help protect the young. The female bird plucks soft down feathers from her breast and uses them to line the nest. If the parent birds have to leave the nest, they pull the down over the eggs. This keeps the eggs warm and helps hide them from enemies, such as gulls and foxes.



Walrus
(*Odobenus rosmarus*)
Length: up to
11 ft 5 in (3.5 m)
Tusks: up to
39 in (100 cm)

Digging teeth

The walrus has long tusks, which it uses to dig up shellfish and other small animals from the sea bed. Walrus live in large groups and spend much of the day sleeping. In the breeding season, walrus gather together and males compete against each other to win mates.



Few animals live on the frozen polar ice cap, as there are no plants or insects to provide food.

ARCTIC OCEAN
• NORTH POLE

Areas of the Arctic that are not permanently covered in ice are known as tundra, which is frozen under the surface.

Much of the island of Greenland is covered in flowing rivers of ice, called glaciers.